Pictorial Works

H 1935

A. Background 1
B. Recent revisions 2
C. Definition 2
D. General rules 2
D.1. Works consisting entirely or primarily of pictures 2
D.2. Works consisting of text with illustrations 2
D.3. Works that are primarily textual 3
D.4. Usage of --Pictorial works 3
E. Exceptions to the general rules 3
E.1. Classes of persons and ethnic groups 3
E.2. Individual persons 4
E.3. Art 4
E.4. Illustrations 4
E.5. Photography 4
E.6. Scientific and technical atlases 4
E.7. Films, video recordings, filmstrips, etc. 4
E.8. Photographs 5
F. Extended examples 5
Revision history 6

A. Background

The subdivision ***--Pictorial works*** is a free-floating form subdivision used for works consisting primarily of pictures. When appropriate, this subdivision may be further subdivided by other form subdivisions, such as ***--Periodicals***.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Exhibition catalogs***.

For guidelines on place as a theme in art, see H 910. For guidelines on art and fine art, see H 1250. For guidelines on artistic photography, see H 1255. For guidelines on illustrations, see H 1659.

B. Recent revisions

2026-03: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definition

Pictorial works: generally resources that consist entirely or predominantly of pictures or of pictures accompanied only by captions and/or brief introductory text

D. General rules

D.1. Works consisting entirely or primarily of pictures

If the work being cataloged consists entirely of pictures or of pictures accompanied only by captions and/or brief introductory text, add the form subdivision ***--Pictorial works*** to the headings being assigned to represent the topical focus of the work. Use this subdivision when the intent is to convey visual information about the subject.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the topical focus of the work. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. ***Illustrated works***.

D.2. Works consisting of text with illustrations

If the work being cataloged consists of text accompanied by illustrations, assign an additional heading to bring out the pictorial aspect, but only under the following conditions: (1) more than 50% of the work is pictorial, and (2) the publication features, or stresses the importance of, the pictures, by using a term such as illustrated as part of the title, by giving special credit to the photographer, etc.

Example:

```
Title: Peoples of the world, in color.
   650 #0 $a Ethnology.
   650 #0 $a Ethnology $v Pictorial works.
LC practice:
   650 #0 $a Ethnology.
```

```
655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft
```

Do not add the additional heading if the illustrations are routine or incidental, such as those present in a typical high school textbook.

D.3. Works that are primarily textual

If less than 50% of the work being cataloged consists of illustrations, do not bring out the pictorial aspect, regardless of the importance of the illustrations.

D.4. Usage of *--Pictorial works*

Use ***--Pictorial works*** under topical headings, individual wars, classes of persons, ethnic groups, names of individual persons and families, names of countries, cities, etc., and named entities, such as individual parks, structures, etc.

Note: Under names of places, this subdivision replaced the subdivisions ***--Description--Views*** and ***--Description and travel--Views***, which were discontinued in 1991. ***--Pictorial works*** is used directly after names of places without interposing the subdivision ***--Description and travel***.

Example:

```
United States--Pictorial works.
[not United States--Description and travel--Pictorial works].
```

E. Exceptions to the general rules

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the topical focus of the work. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. ***Illustrated works***.

E.1. Classes of persons and ethnic groups

For a pictorial work about a class of persons or ethnic group that stresses the visual identity of the individuals, assign the appropriate heading for the class of persons or ethnic group with the subdivision ***--Portraits*** rather than ***--Pictorial works***.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the class of persons or ethnic group when the visual identity of the individuals is emphasized. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. ***Portraits***.

E.2. Individual persons

For a pictorial work about an individual person, use as appropriate, either ***--Art***, ***--Caricatures and cartoons***, ***--Pictorial works***, or ***--Portraits***. See H 1110 for instructions on using these subdivisions.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the individual person who is the focus of the work. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. ***Portraits***.

E.3. Art

For works consisting of art reproductions that depict a particular theme, place, or corporate body in art, assign headings of the type ***[topic] in art*** or ***[place]--In art***, for example, ***Animals in art***; ***Paris (France)--In art***; ***Catholic Church--In art***. The use of the free-floating phrase ***[. . .] in art*** was discontinued in 1997; all headings of this type must now be established.

E.4. Illustrations

For collections of pictorial representations found in types of published materials, individual literatures and literary forms, the works of individual authors, individual works, and sacred works, use the subdivision ***--Illustrations***. See H 1659 for complete instructions on use of the subdivision.

E.5. Photography

For works on photography containing reproductions of photographs where the focus is on their photographic aspect, assign headings of the type ***Photography***; ***Photography, Artistic***; ***Nature photography***; ***Photography of food***. See H 1255 for instructions on artistic photography.

E.6. Scientific and technical atlases

For scientific or technical works consisting of comprehensive, often systematically arranged, collections of illustrative plates, charts, etc., usually with explanatory captions, use the subdivision ***--Atlases*** under topics, for example, ***Human anatomy--Atlases***.

E.7. Films, video recordings, filmstrips, etc.

Do not use ***--Pictorial works*** as a form subdivision for such materials. Assign no form subdivision to adult moving image materials; assign ***--Juvenile films*** to juvenile materials.

E.8. Photographs

For works consisting of actual photographs, that is, photographic prints or digital photographs, rather than reproductions of photographs, use the subdivision ***--Photographs*** under subjects. For aerial photographs, see H 1210.5. For works consisting of slides, use the subdivision ***--Slides***.

F. Extended examples

Title: Costume : an illustrated survey from ancient times to the twentieth century. [includes text]

650 #0 $a Clothing and dress $x History.

650 #0 $a Clothing and dress $x History $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Clothing and dress $x History.

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: Aspects of Boston. [includes text with separate pictorial section]

651 #0 $a Boston (Mass.) $v Pictorial works.

651 #0 $a Boston (Mass.) $x History.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Boston (Mass.) $x History.

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: In praise of Australian birds.

650 #0 $a Birds $z Australia $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Birds $z Australia.

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: A Yosemite album.

651 #0 $a Yosemite National Park (Calif.) $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Yosemite National Park (Calif.)

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: Picture panorama of British history.

651 #0 $a Great Britain $x History $v Pictorial works $v Juvenile literature.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Great Britain $x History.

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt

Title: Pompéi : résurrection d'une cité.

651 #0 $a Pompeii (Extinct city) $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Pompeii (Extinct city)

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: London : a picture-book to remember her by.

651 #0 $a London (England) $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a London (England)

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Title: Australia, colourful continent.

651 #0 $a Australia $v Pictorial works.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Australia.

655 #7 $a Illustrated works. $2 lcgft

Revision history

2026-03: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.